as a first-class platform using Metal acceleration. LM Studio supports both llama.cpp and MLX runtimes on Apple Silicon.

Capacity still is not everything. Memory bandwidth varies enormously between Mac configurations, and bandwidth affects token-generation performance. Apple's current hardware makes the relationship obvious: the 2026 M6 supports up to 32GB unified memory and 170GB/s bandwidth, while higher-end Mac Studio hardware reaches vastly larger memory pools and hundreds of gigabytes per second of bandwidth.

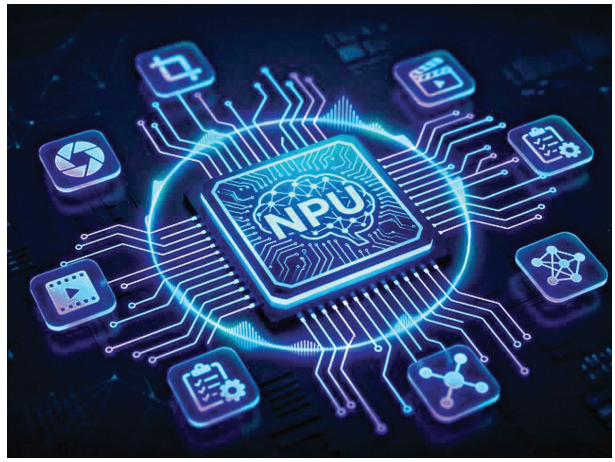
The practical advice is simple: if buying a Mac specifically for local models, pay unusually close attention to unified-memory capacity. You cannot add more later.

The NPU trap: 50 TOPS does not mean "runs every LLM"

Modern AI PCs advertise NPUs aggressively. These low-power accelerators are useful for on-device AI workloads such as background effects, image processing and models specifically optimised for them. What they are not is a universal replacement for a GPU.

Your local-model runtime must explicitly support the NPU, the model needs a compatible execution path, and operators and quantisation formats need to work correctly. llama.cpp's OpenVINO backend now supports Intel CPUs, GPUs and NPUs and has been validated on Core Ultra AI PCs, but its documentation still describes some quantised-model accuracy and performance optimisation as work in progress.

This is why comparing "48 NPU TOPS" with "500 GPU AI TOPS" does not tell you how quickly your favourite GGUF will answer.



For this Fast Track, consider the NPU a bonus unless the runtime you plan to use explicitly supports it. For mainstream downloadable LLMs today, CPU, GPU and memory capacity remain the more useful specifications to examine first.

Integrated graphics: do not dismiss them

Integrated GPUs share system memory and historically offered modest compute performance, but they are becoming more relevant to local inference. llama.cpp supports Intel graphics through SYCL and Vulkan routes, while Vulkan can also widen compatibility across other GPU vendors. Ollama's Vulkan support similarly aims to use additional GPU hardware beyond its primary NVIDIA and AMD paths.

Shared memory can help with capacity because an integrated GPU is not confined to a small dedicated VRAM pool. The down-

